

Bealtaine

by Geraint Warlow

General Practitioner

McCarthy had spotted the light on and the car parked at the side of the house. It was dark and the road was darker, only punctuated by the distant orange glow of the sky where the farm gates broke the hedgerow. It was damp. Muggy. Close. McCarthy had been drinking. More tonight than for a while. He had clipped the headlight on the stone wall on the outside bend, left the car and walked up the lane in the darkness.

Williams watched McCarthy scale the short fence from the sitting room. The gates were closed and locked. The wood was slimy from the recent warm rain, causing him to slip on his heel and thump into the ditch. He was at an awkward angle with his jacket caught in the chainlink.

The security sensor clicked on, casting a homely, incandescent light and exaggerated the outline of McCarthy's rise from the mud and broken flagstones. He rose and, violently pulling on the stuck jacket, slipped again. Now prone, he cast no shadow and Williams lost sight of him.

A car passing at speed illuminated the backdrop, the bluish light bringing out a brief, unnatural green in the sycamore and blackthorn. The car

continued into the distance. It was darker now, and late. Williams gently opened the window. McCarthy groaned pathetically.

‘Why the Jesus are the gates locked?’. McCarthy was livid. He was slurring.

‘Are you alright, John?’ Williams’ voice was tired and flat. A tone too casual. He loathed his own insincerity and quickly straightened up, clenched his jaw and closed the window.

McCarthy was standing by the time Williams reached him. In the cold air, a deep stench of fags and grime hummed off him. The light clicked off and the two men faced each other in darkness.

‘Sure, the car is fecked. The road is too narrow now. It’s too...’. He was distracted now. Grunting.

McCarthy was volatile. Unpredictable, even in his rare sober moments. Williams kept a measured distance. He wanted to direct what happened next but he knew that would be unlikely.

Williams felt his shoulders tense in the cold and in irritation.

He closed his eyes, breathed and felt some release.

‘Come in John’.

* * *

A cold lightbulb hung in the kitchen. A couple of fat moths flitted and pinged a silhouette on the bare wall. McCarthy sat roughly on the pine chair, boots fresh with mud, cheeks ruddy with spidery thread veins. His nostrils dripped with thin mucus, drying to a crust in his moustache and creating a damp patch on his paunch.

The two men sat silently. The clock, fridge and metronomic ding of two moths separated them from the country silence.

Williams had grown used to the unsociability of some countymen. Even with ten pints in them, meaningful conversation was sparse. He wondered about their internal landscape, their monologue, their voice. Conversations about frost, the roads, the weather, the mart. Was McCarthy so violently dull that there was only the void in there? Thank God for the women.

McCarthy pulled an apple tart across the table and carved out a wide slice with a butter knife. Using his filthy left hand as a plate, he ate without pleasure and threw a glance that suggested he may be calmer.

‘Bill was at Tobin’s’.

McCarthy was struggling to modulate the volume of his voice. Williams could see his eyes subtly darting and imagined that McCarthy was unable to focus on a point. He decided that some body parts handled booze better than others.

McCarthy belched and swallowed his vomit. His stench intolerable in the closed space.

‘He’s given Mairead a dozen eggs. Gave them to Sean’s boy to bury in the ditch. She’s hopping’

McCarthy had left Mairead when she was twenty. Went to Liverpool. Told nobody.

‘She found him and gave him a chocolate. Pelted them at Bill. A dozen bleedin eggs. All over...’ McCarthy was humourless.

Williams shifted his weight. His sobriety frustrated him. He admired McCarthy’s dedication to the drink and the ethanoic aura that encased him away from the level-headed drudgery of the ordinary realm. Whiskey transubstantiated the ether. Lager kept him hydrated.

‘I’m going’. McCarthy rose and steadied himself.

‘See you’.

‘I’ll get the car tomorrow’

McCarthy set across the gravel driveway, scrambled over the low wall and waved with his back turned. Williams watched the light come on in the distance, and satisfied that McCarthy had made it home, flicked on the kettle. He threw a dead moth out of the window.

* * *

Williams stood on the driveway. He leaned on the squat, tarred gatepost and contemplated the lichen. How did it grow on the bitumen? No vapour from his breath. It was warming up. The far post had attracted an

excitement of flies. Fox shit maybe. Or Gzregorz's dog. Williams threw his cold tea in the ditch and moved to look.

He waved away the flies. A shrew had been freshly nailed to the wood. Sticky blood stopped an inch from its hind legs, the moist cool air kept it from drying. The flies instantly returned.

Williams panicked. He had planned to go to early mass. To get milk and bread and to deal with the furze in the far corner of the middle field. Buy diesel. Fix a handle. Hang the laundry. And it was May bank holiday. He would not be the only one.

The bluebells around the gate were bent over. Half a yard away was a distinct footprint, the clay mud still glossy and the edges distinct. His thoughts turmoiled – this happened recently. She may still be here. Watching. Hammer in hand. He was hyperventilating, torn between fleeing to the house or the road. A heavy ball in his throat, his stereo heartbeat pounded his ears.

Williams kneeled. The dewdrops sparkled up close. Tiny webs shimmered next to their miniature owners. Flecks of minerals and ancient sand caught the light. Williams buried his head in the grass. The blades curled in his ears and the cool condensate calmed his hot cheeks. He longed to rest on the bedrock below the heavy, permanent earth and stay there away away away from all of this.

He lay down, pressing his head into the ground, communing with the field. His heart slowed. He closed his eyes and gathered up the moisture next to him balming his crown. On the second sweep, his hands pushed into a crown of thistle, antagonising an old gash on his index finger.

He flinched.

'Get feckin up you stupid feckin fecker. Get up!'

Williams's chest lept and fell.

He felt some protection from McCarthy's mad anger, knowing it was directed elsewhere.

Bill and McCarthy stood at the gate. Bill was a choiceless, feeble man. Pale and sickly, even in his youth. McCarthy was burnished bronze and full of crimson rage. The low, rising sun forced him to squint but illuminated him. The butt of a shotgun gleamed.

Williams rose, sheepishly.

‘That piseog witch. It was forty years ago’

McCarthy had left Mairead. He had slept with Dearbhla, Mairead’s twin, claiming that he was too drunk to realise the difference. Bill married Dearbhla soon after and raised the child as his own. Nobody was sure if Bill knew. Williams was guilty by association.

‘Come on’ McCarthy was spitting.

‘Come on!’ He was screaming.

‘I...I...no’ Williams found himself backing away. McCarthy quickly closed in to the gate.

Bill looked away, acted distracted by the swifts overhead. What was he thinking, starting all this?

McCarthy found the shrew, ripped it off the nail and lobbed it at Williams, landing near his boots. It’s pleading, dulled eyes perpendicular to its torso. A passing greenbottle landed on its neck. McCarthy unsheathed the gun from his trouser leg and single handedly pointed it at Williams.

‘Now’. McCarthy’s voice spared no intention.

Williams was subjugated. He silently opened the padlock with the keys from his pocket and pulled through the chain.

‘Bring that’ McCarthy gestured toward the chain with the muzzle.

Williams mustered some superiority over McCarthy, knowing that his gun license was well expired. The local gardai had told him it wouldn’t be renewed.

The three set down the road in a row. McCarthy’s pigeon chested hubris was peaking. It was infectious for Bill who had affected a stride too long for his legs. Williams felt a baseless purpose and was running with it. They passed the grey rendered bungalows of the neighbours and drew closer to Mairead’s.

Her house was set back on a hairpin slope. In the iron gate arch grew ivy and honeysuckle. The sun was behind them and dappled the path.

McCarthy stalled. He had not touched this gate in four decades. He made a low noise and his hands fell. His frame blocked most of the arch.

Williams could hear chatter near the house but could not see.

‘What is it, John?’

‘I...’

‘Who?’

Footsteps crunched down the chippings.

‘John’. It was Mairead. ‘Come in ye big eejit’. She sounded warm. Jocular. Welcoming. ‘And your friends’.

The gentle upward slope of the lawn was green and neat. Daisies and fleabane grew in clumps. The morning dew gone until night. A woman sat on the picnic bench. Another on the grass, with a small child at her breast. Williams flushed and looked at the sky.

McCarthy pushed the gunbarrel down into his waist causing him to swing his right leg from the hip. He was silent. He caught the back of his neck and fidgeted with his hands. Williams kept a fair distance. Bill pretended the latch wouldn’t close. The child waddled to her feet and looked to the gate.

‘Bill – I’ve some mushrooms here if you want. For your omelette!’.
Mairead was delighted.

Bill opened the gate and walked away. Williams didn’t see his face.

Mairead rolled her eyes and, still beaming, turned to face them.

‘John... I wanted to show you someone’. She deftly raised the child to her chest. ‘Thanks for coming’.

McCarthy was meek. Lost for something to say.

‘This is Cara, John...’.

Williams was closer now. The child coyly put an arm around Mairead’s thick neck but was unblinkingly transfixed by him. Williams knew babies have blue eyes and big heads for their bodies. Her skin was golden. There was a dribble of her mother’s milk on her chin.

‘Your... our... granddaughter’ she said firmly.

The woman on the grass rose and tidied her long dress, tucking her hair behind her ear.

‘And this is our daughter, Tara. Tara and Cara’.

McCarthy remained still. He breathed in. Williams waited through the gravid silence. The child buried her head into Mairead.

‘I’ve not got long John.’.

Mairead pulled down her vest. A small plastic tube was taped under her collar bone.

McCarthy swayed and sniffed loudly.

‘The shrews...’. His voice was weak.

Mairead gave a belly laugh, incongruous but breaking the tension. Williams' shoulders touched his earlobes.

'That's for luck, John. And for you.', nodding to Williams. 'And him.', dismissively waving at the road. 'I knew it would get you going'.

The buttery sunshine now poured over them, casting long shadows up to the house. Boughs of hawthorne blossom bobbed and the scent of rosemary and distant silage was on the breeze. The now smiling woman walked carefully towards them. McCarthy looked away at the shrubs on the path.

"De herd. Eight have mastitis. The milking machine needs... and... I'll be going'.

McCarthy turned his back to them and quickly marched through the gate, leaving it open. The gun braced his right knee. He disappeared around the corner and behind the hedge.

Mairead's eyes became narrow and wet. The woman placed a gentle hand on her shoulder. The child unnested herself to look. Williams fixed his gaze beyond them. Over the nettles, a small cloud of midges caught the light.

The chain weighed heavy in his coat.